

Wooden model of
an Egyptian sailboat



3000 BCE

First sailboats

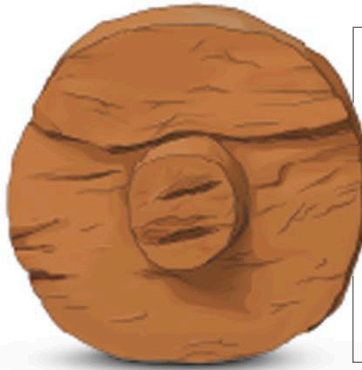
The first boats powered by sails, rather than oars, appeared in Egypt. Sails meant boats could be moved fast by the wind, although they still had oars for rowing against currents or in calm conditions. Early sailboats were made of wooden planks bound together.

Metal-working
See pages
18–19

3500 BCE

Invention of the wheel

Wheels may have developed from simple log rollers. Solid wooden wheels, like the one shown here, were invented in Poland, the Balkans, and Mesopotamia. They were attached to a wagon with a wooden axle rod.



3200 BCE

First production of true bronze

Combining two metals creates an alloy, which is often stronger than the metals themselves. Craftsmen in southwest Asia smelted copper with tin to produce bronze, a much harder metal than copper, and better for making armor and weapons.

5000

4000

3000

5000 BCE

Megaliths in Europe

Across western Europe, people began to build huge stone structures called megaliths, most likely for religious reasons. Megaliths included circles like Stonehenge in southern England; rows, such as at Carnac in France; and tombs built with stones inside or around them, such as at Newgrange in Ireland.

Stone row at Carnac,
Brittany, France



4100 BCE

First cities

In Mesopotamia, from around this date, some large villages and small towns grew into important centers of government and trade. Remains of these early cities, with their massive palaces and temples, can be seen at sites such as Ur and Uruk in modern-day Iraq.

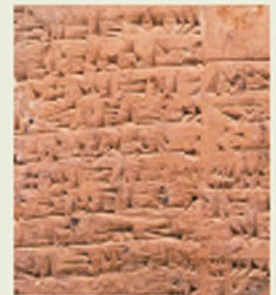
c 3200 BCE

EARLY WRITING

Writing appeared around 3200 BCE in Egypt and Mesopotamia. As towns and cities became more complicated to govern, writing allowed officials to keep accurate records without relying on memory.

Sumerian cuneiform script

The Sumerians, early people of Mesopotamia, invented cuneiform, writing that used pictographs: signs resembling objects. The wedge-shaped script was formed by pressing a pointed reed called a stylus into soft clay.



Egyptian hieroglyphs

Egyptians invented a complicated form of picture writing called hieroglyphics. The symbols, or hieroglyphs, could be carved in stone, cut into clay, or painted on papyrus (paper made from reeds).